the massive rallies at Nanded and Shegaon. It was a full six-month election campaign packed into fourteen days! That kicked off endless meetings (both offline and online), brainstorming sessions and route visits. It is a testament to the Congress party's organizational resilience that the party machinery quickly swung into action and got many of the logistical aspects of the Yatra under way. Each of the aforementioned issues was effectively handled much before the Yatra even reached Nanded, the starting point of the Maharashtra leg.

However, Digvijay Singh (the national convenor for the BJY) had given specific instructions that the BJY was to be a jan-yatra (people's yatra). Even though the Congress party had made all the arrangements, it had to ensure the active participation of every region, community and sector in the BJY, so every major issue in Maharashtra was covered within fourteen days. This was a gargantuan task, because while many stakeholders and organizations are connected to individual leaders, few were institutionally connected to the party organization. Therefore, it was decided that special efforts needed to be undertaken to reach out to non-political forces. Hussain Dalwai (a former Member of Parliament) and Kumar Ketkar (sitting Rajya Sabha Member of Parliament) were asked to chair a civil society outreach committee as elder statesmen, while I was tasked with doing the spade work with ten to twelve key civil society representatives. We were to closely work with an empowered committee run by Satyajit Tambe and Pushparaj Deshpande, which curated all the non-party political interactions with Rahul Gandhi in Maharashtra. We were all ably supported by a large team, which included Rishika Raka, Carina Xavier and Brijbhushan, who handled different aspects of the outreach.

The entire team sat regularly to connect with civil society (which included a huge, amorphous mass of organized and semi-organized individuals, organizations, movements and alliances, collectively working on various people's issues and concerns). For almost three weeks, we called and visited civil society mobilizations across the state. There were meetings that civil society organized in Wardha (led by Dr Ganesh Devy, Sandesh Bhandare, Dhanaji Gurav, Varsha Deshpande, Chetan Shinde, Pallavi